

Tennessee's Koby Bujak-Upton Drops Three Lifetime Bests Ahead of High-Stakes Australian Trials

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Timing is everything in swimming, and Koby Bujak-Upton's timing couldn't be better. The Tennessee **sophomore** who made history last season as the first freshman to break 1:30 in the 200-yard freestyle just delivered a statement performance at the MAC Charlotte Open, clocking lifetime bests in all three **sprint** freestyle distances. With the Australian Trials looming next week in Sydney, Bujak-Upton is riding a wave of **momentum**. In Charlotte, he sliced three-tenths off his 50 free, touching in 22.90 a significant drop from his previous best of 23.20 set in April 2024. He also lowered his 100 free to 48.96 (down from 49.66) and his 200 free to 1:48.44 (previously 1:48.74). Those improvements may seem marginal, but at the elite level, they're the difference between a **podium** finish and watching from the stands. Bujak-Upton's freshman campaign was already the stuff of legend. At the **NCAA** Championships, he placed second in the 200 free with a 1:30.11, cementing his status as one of just nine college swimmers ever to go sub-1:30 in the event. Now, he'll test his **long-course** speed against Australia's best, entered in all three **sprint** freestyle events at Trials. But the Charlotte meet wasn't a one-man show. Sixteen-year-old David Sammons erupted with a slew of personal bests, including a 200 IM (2:03.70), 400 IM (4:20.65), and a 200 fly (1:57.98) that ranks him ninth all-time in the U.S. 15-16 age group. His 400 IM tied for 12th in the same age group's national rankings. Sammons also notched bests in the 50 fly and 200 back, proving he's a name to watch. Tennessee's Lexi Stephens added to the haul with backstroke wins (1:01.40 in the 100, 2:13.60 in the 200), just off her lifetime bests. As the swimming world turns its eyes to Sydney, one question lingers: can Bujak-Upton translate his short-course brilliance to the **long-course** pool and punch his ticket to the biggest stage?

Word Treasure

sophomore -- A student in their second year of college; Koby Bujak-Upton is in his second year at Tennessee.

sprint -- A short, fast swimming race, like the 50- or 100-meter freestyle.

momentum -- A feeling of increasing success and confidence from recent achievements.

podium -- The raised platform where the top finishers stand to receive medals.

NCAA -- The National Collegiate Athletic Association, which organizes college sports in the United States.

long-course -- A 50-meter swimming pool used in the Olympics and international meets, compared to the shorter 25-yard college pools.

Background you need

NCAA swimming in the United States uses 25-yard 'short-course' pools, while the Australian Trials and the Olympics use 50-meter 'long-course' pools; swimmers must adjust their turns, pacing, and race strategy when switching between the two.

Australia has a deep swimming tradition, having produced legends like Ian Thorpe and Emma McKeon; making the national team at Trials is fiercely competitive because only the top finishers earn spots at the World Championships or Olympics.

Koby Bujak-Upton, who holds dual citizenship with Australia and the United States, could be aiming to represent Australia at the Paris 2024 Olympics or future World Aquatics Championships, making these Trials a crucial career stepping stone.

At the NCAA Championships, he finished second in the 200-yard free and became only the ninth swimmer in college history to dip under 1:30 -- a barrier-breaking moment for a freshman.

Break it down

LEAD: Timing is everything -- Bujak-Upton rides a wave of momentum into the Australian Trials

+ - KEY EVENT: Three lifetime bests in sprint freestyle at the MAC Charlotte Open

+ - NUMBERS: Dropped three-tenths in 50 free, also lowered 100 and 200 free times

FRESHMAN CAMPAIGN: Historic second place at NCAA Championships, first freshman sub-1:30 in 200 free

+ - SIGNIFICANCE: One of only nine swimmers ever under that barrier

DEPTH OF MEET: David Sammons broke out with multiple IM and fly personal bests, Lexi Stephens won backstroke events

OPEN QUESTION: Can Bujak-Upton translate short-course brilliance into long-course success at Trials?

Why it matters

For middle-schoolers, Bujak-Upton's story shows that tiny, almost invisible improvements -- just three-tenths of a second -- can be the difference between making a national team and staying home, and that consistent hard work creates opportunities when the biggest moments arrive.

Test what you remember

1. What year of college is Koby Bujak-Upton currently in at the University of Tennessee?
 - (A) Freshman
 - (B) Sophomore
 - (C) Junior
 - (D) Senior
2. By how much did he improve his personal best in the 50 free at the MAC Charlotte Open?
 - (A) One-tenth of a second
 - (B) Three-tenths of a second
 - (C) Half a second
 - (D) One full second
3. What major competition is Bujak-Upton preparing for next?
 - (A) NCAA Championships
 - (B) Australian Trials
 - (C) MAC Charlotte Open
 - (D) World Championships
4. What historic achievement did he earn as a freshman at Tennessee?
 - (A) Won an NCAA title
 - (B) Became the first freshman to break 1:30 in the 200-yard freestyle
 - (C) Set a world record in the 100 free
 - (D) Qualified for the Olympics
5. Which teenage swimmer also made headlines at the same meet with multiple personal bests?
 - (A) Koby Bujak-Upton
 - (B) David Sammons
 - (C) Lexi Stephens
 - (D) An unnamed Australian
6. Where will the Australian Trials take place?
 - (A) Charlotte
 - (B) Sydney
 - (C) Melbourne
 - (D) Tennessee

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive / Optimistic:** Dropping time across all three sprint events signals that he is peaking at exactly the right moment, giving him a strong chance to qualify for Australia's senior national team and gain international experience.
- 2. Negative / Pressured:** High-stakes meets like Trials bring enormous psychological pressure, and the shift from short-course yards to long-course meters is not guaranteed; even tiny mistakes in turns or pacing could cost him a spot.
- 3. Neutral / Analytical:** Swimming success depends on periodization -- training cycles designed to peak at a specific meet. The NCAA season operates in yards, while international swimming uses meters, so athletes who excel in both systems must carefully manage their training and race plans.
- 4. Forward-looking:** If Bujak-Upton makes the Australian team, he could join a new generation of sprint talent and eventually target Olympic medals, helping to reshape the future of Australian men's freestyle swimming.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):